

in the institutes. There has been a lot more awareness over the past 10 years. Ten years back, most of the colleges didn't even know what open source was. They did not have Linux in their labs. Today, it is a very different scenario.

Having said that, I would add that there are two types of colleges—the premium ones that have a much higher penetration of open source in the labs and amongst their students; and there are some other colleges which have to catch up a bit more. So I would say that, over all, the colleges are catching up with open source technology. Moreover, colleges also understand that they have to work with the industry, so they are actually finding ways in which they can collaborate. We have worked with some of the colleges that wanted to understand what kind of curriculum may be good for their students to get jobs... so they wanted to work with us for their projects. We feel that this partnership is really helping in bridging the gap between what academia teaches and what the industry needs.

Q Can the students do internships with you?

A Yes, of course! There are different channels from which we pick students for internships. We pick up the passionate students who have the capability to join us as employees at a later stage. We plug them into our live projects so that they learn our technology better. If students whose college we have not visited want to do an internship with us, they apply to our HR department. We get lots of such requests but we pick and choose from the applications depending upon our need and the students' calibre. Since these internships are on live projects, it requires a lot of investment from the team to bring students on par with the rest and only then can they start contributing. So, we cannot afford to have a large number of them but, yes, quality people are always welcome.

Q Are your clients comfortable with open source solutions? Has the outlook in enterprises changed over the years, regarding open source technology?

A Yes, like I said earlier, the traction is continuously increasing because of various reasons including the cheap cost structure and people not wanting vendor lock-in. But once you say Linux, people immediately think it is a freeware and that security compromised. In a company like Novell or SUSE, it's not just the Open Source software that we download and give. It has some added services as well. What the customers buy is the support of enterprise-class open source software and the technical support of SUSE behind it. So, it is different from what everybody else can download from the internet. There are no reasons for these security concerns. I think what matters is which stack we offer to them. Open Source is a lot more customisable than its proprietary counterparts, so the customers see the advantage..

Q How can any organisation gain by switching to open source tools and platforms?

A If you ask about the scenario today, enterprises would want

to have a mix of open source and proprietary software, depending upon the application. But more and more people want to choose open source. Customers do not want to live with the pain of a vendor lock-in and the fear that comes with it. Also, the cost matters a lot. The total cost of a Linux-based solution is, any day, a whole lot cheaper, as compared to a proprietary solution. Open source allows a lot of customisation, so you can go for whatever features you want. Of course, being open source software, you can add on the applications that the clients want.

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Q How do FOSS platforms or tools add value to a project's development?

A In the teams doing a lot of development, we have seen that engineers tend to use a lot of FOSS tools like Bugzilla. Some of those tools are very basic to the project development. FOSS tools not only bring down costs but some of these tools have really matured over a period of time. They are being worked on by thousands of developers around the world as against one organisation, which is the case with proprietary software tools. For us, it is always good to see the developments happening from the market's point of view and to bring down the overall cost. A lot of open source tools are being used even for projects that are not open source.

Q What are the key tools that you use for product development and which products have they been used for?

A The tools we use are very particular to the platform we work for. If a product is meant for the Windows market, we will obviously use tools that will help us to develop for Windows. But then we also have tools like KDE, iFolder, Open Office, etc. Open Office is used extensively in our organisation. I use it pretty much everyday.

Q How does Attachmate find the right kind of talent to work in its open source projects? And what skill sets do you look for while recruiting your employees?

A The hiring at Attachmate is not different from other open source projects. Having said that, there are some distinct capabilities we look for, especially when we are hiring for open source. We do not have teams in one single location and open source projects